



A family affair

Two brothers, one final — Sayyad and Aakib led from the front in a high-stakes contest.

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When the Railway Sports Promotion Board (RSPB) took on the Indian Navy hockey team in the final of the MCC-Murugappa Gold Cup in Chennai on June 20, a mini-battle ensued in the Rahim household. Cousins Sayyad Niyaz Rahim **(above, blue)** and Aakib Rahim Arif **(above, red)** captained their respective sides, RSPB and the Navy, in the summit clash of one of India's oldest hockey tournaments.

It was Sayyad who won the bragging rights under lights at the Mayor Radhakrishnan Stadium, leading RSPB to its third straight title and sixth since 1996. The defending champion dominated proceedings in the final, overcoming the Navy team 3-1, with both captains scoring on the night.

This wasn't the first instance of the two brothers going head-to-head on the big stage. Aakib and his Navy side triumphed over Sayyad in the Nehru Cup semifinal in 2022, before the elder brother settled the scores in the same tournament last year.

Sayyad and Aakib were born in Nagpur to